

Palace of Westminster

A world-famous landmark in London and the seat of the United Kingdom's parliament

On October 16, 1834, the old Palace of Westminster was destroyed by a fire. Built as a royal residence in medieval times, it had been used as a meeting place for parliaments since 1265 and as a permanent location for the House of Lords and the House of Commons since the 16th century. The only substantial section of the old palace to survive the fire was Westminster Hall, where law courts were located. A competition to design a new building for the site was won by British architect Charles Barry (1795–1860). With the inspired assistance of young designer Augustus Pugin (1812–1852), Barry created the striking edifice in the Gothic Revival style that still stands today.

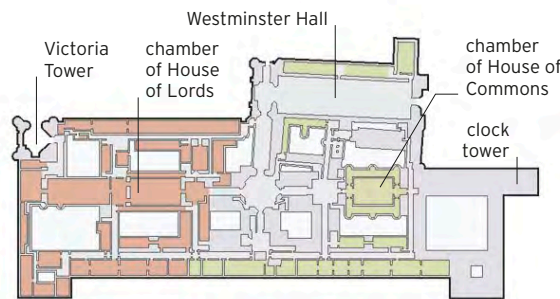
Palace of a thousand rooms

Situated on the north bank of the River Thames, the building is most famous for its clock tower. Pugin's masterpiece, completed in 1859, the tower has clock dials 23 ft (7 m) in diameter and contains five bells, the largest known as Big Ben. The Victoria Tower, at the other end of the building, stands taller at 323 ft (98.5 m) and houses the parliamentary archives. The interior of the palace, which has over a thousand rooms, is a riot of Victorian painting, sculpture, frescoes, mosaics, carved wood, and stained glass.



PLAN OF THE PALACE

The debating chambers of the UK parliament's two houses, the Lords and Commons, occupy only a small part of the palace. The Sovereign's Entrance, used by the Queen at the state opening of parliament, is at the base of the Victoria Tower. Westminster Hall serves for ceremonial occasions.



KEY

House of Lords

House of Commons

▷ SYMBOL OF LONDON

Designed by Pugin, the palace's Gothic clock tower has become an icon of its city. The tower is built of limestone-clad brick with a cast-iron spire.

